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FORMULA 1 HAS, over seven decades, remained one of the foremost sporting attractions globally. And guess what? An Indian company enables the broadcast of the race to over 500 million fans in at least 180 countries. In 2022, Formula 1 and Tata Communications announced a multi-year strategic collaboration, under which the latter was made the official broadcast connectivity partner of the races.

58 | In under 200 milliseconds, video feeds move from the venue of the race to a remote production site in London, before making their way to the viewing device. This is what media companies do, but Tata Communications is not one. Its

to bat for a play in the digital space. The high-value solutions it is targeting call for expertise in cloud computing, mobility, security, artificial intelligence (AI), Internet of Things (IoT), and more.

CHANGE IS CONSTANT

The business model of Tata Communications is not easy to grasp. One reason, among others, is the sheer pace of transformation, from a voice player at the turn of the century to building a big play in data and digital. The company followed strategies in line with what was the need of the hour.

“One of the reasons we are not understood very well is because there is no other comparable company,” says the company’s MD & CEO, A S Lakshminarayanan. Before his current position, he had a long stint with Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), where he was running markets like Japan, the UK and Europe, apart from being the global head of media and information services. “We have an interaction fabric, a network fabric and a cloud

disinvestment process in 2002. Interestingly, difficult situations led to newer opportunities and, inevitably, a different way of thinking. When Lakshminarayanan took charge in October 2019, from a financial perspective, it was a difficult period. Investors were also unhappy. There was nothing remarkable to speak of when it came to customers. “If they wanted five things from us, it was often a case of being able to do 2A or 3B. We were not aiming to solve a problem, and that reduced customer relevance,” he says. What compounded the problems was that the meetings were held with the head of networks, not with the chief information officer (CIO).

AI-FIRST JOURNEY

When a company is in good financial health, other aspects like product, go-to-market and skills can be approached with more confidence and it can make mergers and acquisitions (M&As) more meaningful. Between December 2022 and June 2023, the company made two acquisitions. First was Switch (at \$59

TATA COMMUNICATIONS HAS DEVELOPED IoT, SIGNALLING THAT IT DOES NOT WANT TO BE A PURE-PLAY IT COMPANY, AND WOULD RATHER POSITION ITSELF AS A SERVICES PLAYER

network provides international call services, but it’s not just a telecom company either. It would be best to describe the company as operating at the confluence of both, in a zone called communication technology, courtesy the 5,00,000 km of sub-sea cables that serve enterprises and internet service providers.

All this is enabling the company

fabric. Nobody else has that, and since each of these has a different profile, one cannot put them on a single spreadsheet.”

The metamorphosis of Tata Communications has been an ongoing process and has not been easy. Earlier known as Videsh Sanchar Nigam, the Tata group purchased it from the government through a

million), a live production and video transmission services provider. It then bought Kaleyra, a distressed asset (at \$100 million plus a debt of around \$180 million) that is an integrated communications platform as a service (CPaaS) player. In December 2025, Tata Communications acquired a 51% stake in Commotion Inc, an AI-native SaaS